CHAPTER 19

How to Teach Students to Follow Classroom Procedures

THE KEY IDEA:

A smooth-running classroom is based on the teacher's ability to teach procedures.

The Problem Is Not Discipline

The number one problem in the classroom is not discipline; it is the lack of procedures and routines.

You have now arrived at the two most important chapters in this book. What you are about to read can provide you with a smooth-running, well-oiled learning environment. For this to happen, you must implement the practices and procedures described in Chapters 19 and 20. **The information in these two chapters on classroom management will help you become a proactive teacher and will assist you in reducing the number of misbehaviors in the classroom.**

Effective teachers teach students how to responsibly follow procedures.

Ineffective teachers use controlling tactics to coerce the students into compliance.

A vast majority of the behavior problems in the classroom are caused by the failure of students to follow procedures and routines. There are three main reasons why students do not follow procedures:

1. The teacher has not thought out what happens in the classroom.
2. The students have not been taught how to follow procedures.
3. The teacher spends no time managing the classroom with procedures.

Thus, the students cannot follow procedures that do not exist.

Click to read Sidebar story: **Why You're Frazzled**

What Is Classroom Management?

Classroom management consists of the practices and procedures that a teacher uses to maintain an optimum environment in which instruction and learning can occur.

Classroom management and discipline are not the same. You manage a store; you do not discipline a store. You manage a team; you do not discipline a team. Likewise, effective teachers manage a classroom; they do not discipline a classroom. Teachers who view classroom management as a process of organizing and structuring classroom events tend to be more effective than teachers who view their role as disciplinarian.

Teachers who are effective classroom managers

- have planned procedures for classroom organization.
- have instructional procedures to maximize student engagement.
- systematically teach these procedures.

It is not what teachers do to stop misbehavior that characterizes effective group management, but how they prevent problems in the first place. Effective teachers implement a systematic approach toward classroom management with procedures at the beginning of the school year.

Click to read Sidebar story: **I Knew They Would Do That**

Click to read Sidebar story: **Could I Have the Plans Back?**

Click to read Sidebar story: **Effective and Ineffective Classrooms: A Comparison**

The Person Who Works, Learns

Students readily accept the idea of having a set of uniform classroom procedures because it simplifies the task of succeeding in school. Procedures allow a wide variety of activities to take place during the school day, often simultaneously, with minimal confusion and wasted time. If there are no procedures, much time is wasted organizing and explaining each activity, even for recurring activities. The lack of procedures also leads to students' acquiring undesirable work habits and behaviors that are subsequently hard to correct.

No learning takes place when you discipline. Learning takes place only when a student is at work. Discipline temporarily stops misbehavior and disrupts the learning process.

Effective teachers know that the more time students spend on task, called academic learning time, the more the students learn. Who is working and learning in your classroom?

The Difference Between Discipline and Procedures

Classroom management should not be equated with discipline. Discipline plans have rules. Classroom management plans have procedures. Please DO NOT call a procedure a rule.

Procedures are not found in a discipline plan; nor should a procedure be a threat, a rule, or an order. Procedures lay the groundwork for student learning. **A procedure is simply a method or process for getting things done in the classroom.**

Procedures and routines are different from a discipline plan. Do not confuse procedures with discipline. There are two major differences.

DISCIPLINE concerns how students ***BEHAVE*.**
PROCEDURES concern how things ***ARE DONE*.**

DISCIPLINE ***HAS*** penalties and rewards.
PROCEDURES ***HAVE NO*** penalties or rewards.

A student is generally not penalized for failing to follow a procedure or rewarded if a procedure is followed.

Example of a Procedure

There is a procedure for opening a lock on a locker. It's usually two turns to the right, one turn to the left, and a final turn to the right.

There is no penalty if the procedure is not followed. The lock just does not open. Likewise, there is no reward if the procedure is followed. The lock simply opens. To do anything in life successfully, you simply follow the procedures.

Student success or achievement at the end of the school year is directly related to the degree to which the teacher establishes good control of the classroom procedures in the very first week of the school year. Procedures set the class up for achievement to take place.

A rule is a DARE to be broken, whereas a procedure is not.

A procedure is a DO, a step to be learned.

Why Procedures Are Important

Students must know from the very beginning what they are expected to DO in a classroom work environment. Discipline dictates how they are to behave; procedures and routines teach what they are to do or work at. Procedures and routines offer security. Students cannot get down to the serious business of learning unless they feel secure in the classroom. They want instruction and guidance on all the how-to's in class—how to head a paper, how to ask for help, how to sharpen a pencil, how to get to work, how and when to use the computer, and so on.

Since a **PROCEDURE** explains how you want something done, it is the responsibility of the teacher to have procedures clearly stated. A **ROUTINE** is what the student does automatically, without prompting or supervision.

Procedures are necessary for an effective classroom for several reasons.

- Classroom procedures are statements of student expectations that are necessary to participate successfully in classroom activities, to learn, and to function effectively in the school environment.
- Classroom procedures allow many different activities to take place efficiently during the school day, often several at the same time, with a minimum of wasted time and confusion.
- Classroom procedures increase on-task time and greatly reduce classroom disruptions.
- Classroom procedures tell students how the classroom is organized, thus reducing discipline problems.

PROCEDURE:
What the teacher wants done.

ROUTINE:
What the students do automatically.

Students Accept and Want Procedures

Effective teachers manage with procedures. Every time the teacher wants something done, there must be a procedure or a set of procedures. For instance, have procedures for taking roll, exchanging papers, registering the students on the first day, taking turns speaking, and moving from task to task. If you don't, time that should be spent on learning will be wasted getting these tasks done.

Classroom procedures address such issues as these:

What to do when the bell rings

What to do when the pencil breaks
What to do when you hear an emergency alert signal
What to do when you finish your work early
What to do when you have a question
What to do when you need to go to the restroom

Tell your students that classroom procedures are for their benefit. Following procedures will help them do their work with less confusion and thus help them succeed. Knowledge of classroom procedures tells your students such things as these:

How to enter the classroom
What to do when they enter the classroom
Where to find the assignment
What to do when you want their attention
How a paper is to be done
Where you want the paper placed
What to do if they want to sharpen a pencil
Where to find assignments if they have been absent
What to do upon dismissal of class

Every classroom needs to have a set of procedures, which allow the class to operate smoothly. A smooth-running, effective classroom is free of confusion and is a pleasure to teach and learn in.

***Click to read Sidebar story:* No Need for Discipline**

A smooth-running classroom is the responsibility of the teacher and the result of the teacher's ability to teach procedures.

***Click to read Sidebar story:* Procedures Are a Part of Life**

Procedures Are Part of Life

Procedures are important in society so that people can function in an acceptable and organized manner. Everyday life is full of procedures—for instance:

Telephone directory. At the front of a telephone book are procedures on how to make a long-distance call, make a foreign call, contact directory assistance, get emergency help, upgrade your services, and contact the business office.

Airplane. After the "discipline plan" is stated at the beginning of the flight, (and yes, there are penalties and fines associated with those rules) the flight attendants explain the procedures. These procedures include how to fasten the seat belt, how to use the oxygen mask, where to find the life vest, and how to find the aisle in case the cabin fills with smoke.

Elevator. If you are waiting to enter the elevator, step aside to allow passengers to exit before you enter. If you are already on the elevator when more passengers enter, step to the back of the elevator and make room for the new arrivals. Or, if your floor is the next stop, step out, allow new passengers to enter, and then reboard.

Wedding. At the conclusion of a wedding ceremony, a procedure is followed. The bride, groom, and wedding party leave. They are followed by the parents in the first row, who are followed by each row of guests from the front of the seating area.

Procedures demonstrate how people are to function in an acceptable and organized manner. When we say that someone is ill-mannered, it is because that person doesn't know or doesn't care about the local customs, culture, or procedures. To function successfully with classmates and other people, the best guideline is the old saying, "When in Rome, do as the Romans do."

In the first few days of school, teach only procedures necessary for the smooth opening of class.

Delay the other procedures until the appropriate activity arises.

Procedures Are Part of School Life

As in everyday life, procedures must be followed in the classroom. Here are some that nearly every teacher must teach.

Procedure for Dismissal at the End of the Period or Day. When the dismissal bell rings, are the students already standing at the door waiting to leave, or do they just get up and leave, even if you are in the middle of a sentence? You can always tell who is running the class—the students or the teacher—by how the students behave at the end of the period or day.

Procedure for Quieting a Class. Do you know how to quiet a class in 15 seconds or less? It can be done easily! Do you yell, scream, and flick the lights—all to no avail? Or if you do succeed, does it take a long time to get the students' attention, not to mention years off your life span from stress?

Procedure for the Start of the Period or Day. When the students enter, do they know what to do, where to sit, and what materials to have ready? Or do they sit and wait for the teacher to tell them what to do?

Procedure for Students Seeking Help. Do your students raise their hands when they want your help, flapping their hands to attract your attention, calling your name at the same time, stopping work in the process, accompanied by muttering and complaining to their classmates because you do not respond instantly?

Procedure for the Movement of Students and Papers. Do your students take forever to pass their papers in and even longer to change from group to group or task to task? And when they turn their papers in, do they throw them in a pile on your desk or punch each other in the back as the papers are passed forward?

The Three-Step Approach to Teaching Classroom Procedures

Most behavior problems in the classroom are caused by the teacher's failure to teach students how to follow procedures. Telling is not teaching. Students must be physically engaged in the process if you want them to learn it.

The Three Steps to Teaching Procedures

1. **Teach.** State, explain, model, and demonstrate the procedure.
2. **Rehearse.** Rehearse and practice the procedure under your supervision.
3. **Reinforce.** Reteach, rehearse, practice, and reinforce the classroom procedure until it becomes a student habit or routine.

Step 1. Teach Classroom Procedures Clearly

Effective teachers know what activities need to be done and have worked out the procedures for each of them. These procedures are posted or distributed to the students early in the school year or when the activity surfaces in class. Unless the students read well, primary grade teachers should explain the procedures verbally rather than post them.

It is essential that you have the procedures for each opening-of-school activity ready on the first day of school. Revise and hone these procedures year after year until they become models of efficiency. Remember that the effective teacher has a script for the first day of school.

Step 2. Rehearse Classroom Procedures Until They Become Routines

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All procedures must be rehearsed!

Effective teachers spend a good deal of time during the first weeks of school introducing, teaching, modeling, and rehearsing procedures. Do not expect the students to learn all the procedures in one day, especially at the elementary school level. Behaviors must be taught, modeled, practiced, monitored, and retaught.

Watch a good music, drama, athletic, or foreign-language coach. Such people are masters at the rehearsal technique. They tell and show you a technique, even have you watch a video of the technique. Then they have you do it repeatedly while they watch you. Some people call this technique "guided practice."

Parents have their children practice the piano because the more they practice, the better they play. The reason coaches have their teams run the plays over and over again is that the more they run the plays, the better they will be able to execute the plays during the game.

Rehearse

- Have students practice the procedure, step by step, under your supervision. After each step, make sure the students have performed it correctly.
- Have students repeat the procedure until it becomes a routine. The students should be able to perform the procedure automatically without teacher supervision.

Click to read Sidebar story: **Run the Play, Sing the Song**

Step 3. Reinforce a Correct Procedure and Reteach an Incorrect One

Again, watch a coach, because good coaches are the best teachers. As the coach guides a team, class, or student through practice, corrections are made instantly. The coach tells, shows, demonstrates, cajoles, and even loudly calls out commands until the task is done right.

And when it is done right, the coach responds with words of praise, hugs, pats, and smiles. But good coaches don't stop there. They reinforce the correct technique by having the student do the

acquired technique over and over again, each time exhorting the student to do it better.

Reinforce

- Determine whether students have learned the procedure or whether they need further explanation, demonstration, or practice.
- Reteach the correct procedure if rehearsal is unacceptable and give corrective feedback.
- Acknowledge the students when the rehearsal is acceptable.

Click to see sample signs of classroom procedures

***Click for GoBe folder information:* I Did Not Start on the First Day of School**

Using the Three-Step Approach to Teach Procedures

The following are examples of how some procedures are taught. You may not need or want them, but note how each procedure is taught. Then substitute your own procedure, using the **teach**, **rehearse**, **reinforce** technique just described.

- How to dismiss a class
- How to quiet a class and gain the students' attention
- How students are to ask you for help
- How students are to pass in papers
- What to do during transition
- How to take lecture notes
- How to complete a rubric

***Click to read Sidebar story:* For Whom Does the Bell Toll?**

Procedure for Dismissal at the End of the Period

Teach

Students, there is a procedure at the end of the period. You are to remain in your seat (or at your desks with the chairs pushed in) until I dismiss the class. The bell does not dismiss the class. You do not dismiss the class. The teacher dismisses the class. Thank you.

You will want to explain the criteria for dismissal, such as how clean you want the desk or work area, and where and how you want the chairs and equipment to be positioned. Show and demonstrate this procedure. Have several students (never one, because it creates a show-off situation) demonstrate the procedure. Praise each so the students know that you are validating the correct procedure.

Rehearse

Be alert a few seconds before the bell rings on the first day of school. Anticipate that you will need to make an immediate correction if the procedure is not followed. If the class starts to file out, it is too late to correct the procedure. The failure to correct a procedure will only escalate the problem until the students dismiss themselves and are really the ones in control of the class.

On the first day of school, remind the class of the dismissal procedure a few seconds before the bell rings at the end of the period or day. This will reduce the hassle of correcting the class; however, if any students begin to leave at the bell, simply say,

No, no, no. Tom, Joel, Anne, please return to your desks.

Do not scold, yell, or demean. And do not use meaningless phrases or questions like “Listen to me” or “What did I say about the dismissal procedure?” You do not want a discussion, an argument, or a response. You want all students at their desks. Calmly, but in a voice of authority, tell the students who began to leave to return to their desks.

Reinforce

Every time a procedure needs to be corrected—

1. **REMIND** the class of the procedure.
2. Have the class **EXPERIENCE** the procedure.

> **Remind:** *Class, I would like to remind you of the procedure at the end of the period. You are to remain at your desks until I dismiss the class.*
>
> **Experience:** *Look around the room. You are all at your desks (and your chairs are pushed in). This is the correct procedure, and I thank you for doing it correctly.*
>
> *Well done. Please do it again tomorrow. Have a nice day!*

Effective teachers have the students see, feel, and experience each procedure. The students see all the others remaining in their seats and experience the procedure correctly. Ineffective teachers only tell students what to do. The students do not experience what should be done. That is why many teachers fail when they want students to follow procedures.

Rehearse the procedure every day to reinforce the procedure until it becomes a routine. By the end of the third or fourth day, the procedure will have become automatic.

Thereafter, all you need to do a few seconds after the bell rings is smile and say, “It’s been nice seeing all of you. See you tomorrow. Have a nice day.” This is much better than, “You’re dismissed.”

Click to read Sidebar story: **Why Children Never Tell Mom They Are Going Out**

Click to read Sidebar story: **How to Teach a New Student All the Class Procedures**

Click to read Sidebar story: **The Greatest Gift**

Procedure for Quieting a Class

Click to read Sidebar story: **Procedures Are Everywhere**

Teach

Students, I have a procedure when I want your undivided attention. You will see me stand here with my hand up. Or I may tap a bell because some of you will not be able to see my hand while you are working in a group. When you see my hand or hear a bell, the procedure is as follows:

1. *Freeze.*
2. *Turn and face me; pay attention; and keep your eyes on me.*
3. *Be ready for instruction. I will have something to say.*

Let me repeat and demonstrate what I said.

Repeat and look for class understanding.

Byron, please tell me the procedure when you see my hand or hear a bell.

Byron does so.

Yes, yes, yes. Thank you, Byron.

Repeat this with several more students.

Is there anyone who does not understand or know what to do if you see my hand or hear a bell?

Rehearse

Good, let's rehearse the procedure. We will be working together this year, so let's get to know one another. Please look at the person to the right of you. You will have two minutes to introduce yourselves and get to know one another.

After two minutes, hold up your hand or ring the bell, perhaps doing both this first time. Do not say a word when you raise your hand. Do the demonstration exactly as you will be doing it for the rest of the year. Be patient and wait until the class does the three steps and pays attention.

Do not give up as you wait for the students to give you their undivided attention. Compliment them when you have their attention.

Thank you. You practiced the procedure correctly.

Now please look at the person to the left of you. You may have two minutes to introduce yourself and get acquainted.

After two minutes, hold up your hand or ring the bell. Compliment them when they have complied.

Thank you. You followed the procedure correctly.

We are not finished with the rehearsal. You will often find yourself out of your seat—working in groups or alone somewhere in the room away from your seat. So let's try a different scenario.

I would like two of you to stand by the pencil sharpener, two of you at the sink, two of you at the bookcase, and one of you at the computer.

You then hold up your hand and watch for the seven students to pay attention.

Reinforce

Thank you. That was the correct procedure when you see my hand or hear a bell. Please do the same thing each time you see

my hand or hear a bell.

You keep using the same language because you must use the same procedure if you want the students to exhibit the same routine.

Click to read Sidebar story: **Praise the Deed, Encourage the Student**

Click to read Sidebar story: **She Quieted 100 People in Five Seconds**

The "Give Me Five" hand signal is not the only way to quiet a class or group. Create your own technique or steal from the list that follows:

1. A principal holds up an orange card at an assembly and can quiet an entire student body in seconds.
2. Many teachers simply say, "May I have your attention, please?"
3. A Texas teacher says, S-A-L-A-M-E, which rehearses out to Stop and Look at ME.
4. A football coach says, "Gentlemen, please."
5. A teacher in Arizona plays a table-top chime.
6. A pre-K teacher sings a song.

Click to read Sidebar story: **Works With 800!**

Procedure for Students Seeking Help

Hand raising is not effective when students want your attention. There are better methods for students to use to get your attention.

The class is at work and you are walking around the room helping. You see a hand up and say, "Pam." The whole class stops to look at you and Pam.

Pam says, "May I sharpen my pencil?"—a reasonable request.

You say, "Yes," or "No," and the class goes back to work.

A few seconds later, you see another hand up. You say, “Carlos,” and the whole class stops to look at you and Carlos.

Carlos says, “I need your help”—an appropriate request.

You say, “Wait a minute,” and the class goes back to work.

Every time you speak, you interrupt the class. These interruptions can occur frequently, often two or three times a minute.

You would be distracted if the principal beamed announcements two or three times a day, no less two or three times a minute. Before you complain that the principal creates too many interruptions during the day, consider how many times a teacher interrupts a class when the students are concentrating on their work.

Student Methods for Getting the Teacher’s Attention Without Interrupting the Class

Hand signal: The student signals with different numbers of fingers.

Toilet tissue tube: The student signals with a colored tube.

Styrofoam cup: The student signals with the position of a cup.

Index card: The student signals with a message on an index card.

Textbook: The student signals with an upright textbook.

Hand Signal

With this technique the students signal the teacher with a predetermined number of fingers. The number of fingers raised corresponds to a

predetermined request established by the teacher.

Post a sign on the wall with your hand signal chart. Then train your students to use the system.

- If they wish to speak, they are to raise the index finger.
- If they wish to leave their seat, they are to raise two fingers.
- If they need your help, they are to raise three fingers.
- If they need to go to the bathroom, they cross two fingers.

When you see a signal, silently respond to the signal with a nod or shake of the head or a gesture of the hand.

To Obtain the Teacher's Attention, Raise—
One Finger: "I wish to speak."
Two Fingers: "I wish to leave my seat."
Three Fingers: "I need your help."

The important thing is that the class is not disturbed.

***Click to read Sidebar story:* A Difference in the Noise Level Alone**

Toilet Tissue Tube

Use an empty toilet tissue tube and wrap one end with red construction paper and the other end with green construction paper. The tube is placed with the green end up on the student's desk.

The procedure when the student wants the teacher's attention is to turn the tube so the red end is up and to **continue to work**. When the teacher comes to help the student, the green end is turned back up.

Styrofoam Cup

Tape a short length of string to the bottom of a Styrofoam cup. (Styrofoam cups are noiseless.) Tape the other end of the string near the edge of the

desktop, and leave the cup dangling off the table.

The procedure when the student wants the teacher's attention is to place the cup on the desk and to **continue to work**.

Index Card



Fold and tape an index card into a three-sided pyramid. On one side write, "Please help me." On another side write, "Please keep working." Leave the third side blank. Place the card on the table so the blank side is facing the student.

The procedure when the student wants the teacher's attention is to turn the card so that "Please help me" is facing forward. The student sees "Please keep working" and is reminded **to continue to work**.



Textbook

High school teachers may appreciate this simple system. The procedure when the student wants the teacher's attention is to take a textbook and place it in an upright position and to **continue to work**.

Instructional Procedures for Student Learning

Just as there are classroom procedures that organize the structure of the classroom, there are Instructional Procedures that govern the academic work of the students.

Some basic instructional procedures include the following:

1. How to work in groups
2. How to take lecture notes
3. How to read the textbook
4. How to do the homework
5. How to summarize each day's learning

These procedures apply to any subject or content area. Just as classroom procedures lay the foundation for structuring the classroom, instructional procedures lay the foundation for acquiring information and learning.

What If Procedures Do Not Work?

They just won't stop talking. What about the kid who blurts out? What if…? Here are the four most frequently asked questions about procedures:

1. **What if they do not do the procedure?** "I tell them, I remind them over and over again and they just will not do it" is the anguished statement made most often. Just telling someone will not get them to do it. A procedure must be rehearsed and rehearsed.
2. **What if they forget the procedure?** Students forget and blurt out in class. We all forget. A student knows the procedure, but just forgets. There is no need to rehearse it again as there is a much better, quicker, and saner way. Just say,

"And what's the procedure, please?"

Stand in front of a mirror and calmly repeat this statement over and over again a thousand times until it becomes an automatic response to you. This is the statement:

The reason a student is failing is typically because the student has not done the work, and failure to do the work results in failing grades in the classroom. Most at-promise students are failing because they have not been taught many of the academic procedures discussed in Unit D. These techniques offer at-promise students opportunities to succeed.

- How to take lecture notes
- How to read a book
- How to do the homework
- How to work in groups
- How to understand the assignment
- How to study for the test
- And a plethora of other things students are expected to DO in the classroom (Note the word DO, rather than behave.)

Here is the #1 solution for helping at-promise students.

They need STRUCTURE!

In a well-managed classroom students are taught how to **DO** things. They are taught structure—the structure of how to do things. We compound the disadvantage of students who are at-risk, when we place them in a classroom that lacks STRUCTURE (translation: disorganized and chaotic).

- The Effective Classroom has STRUCTURE.
- Procedures + Routines create STRUCTURE.
- Effective teachers manage and instruct with PROCEDURES and ROUTINES.

Procedures give students and teachers structure. Many students come from dysfunctional (unstructured) homes. The effective teacher provides structure so students have something **familiar and secure they can rely on.**

Having special procedures is reassuring to a student—it gives the student something to fall back on. Procedures don't have to be elaborate, but they need to have a certain regularity—consistency. They can be as simple as knowing where to line up for an elementary student and knowing where to go quickly in the face of danger for a secondary student. It's ironic that teachers have a lounge where they can retreat, but students do not have a safe haven where they can retreat.

Once you have procedures in place, you can have responsible students.

The only way to have responsible students and to help students who may be at-risk is to have procedures and routines for which the students can feel responsible.

Click for GoBe folder information: **You're Worth It**

Click to read Sidebar story: **Procedures to Rehearse With Students**

Procedures and routines established early in the school year free up the rest of the year to devote to teaching and learning in the content areas.

Remember, it is the procedures that set up the class for success to take place.

"You seemingly waste a little time at the beginning to gain time at the end."

_Lim Chye Tin

THE EFFECTIVE TEACHER

1. Has well-thought-out and structured procedures for every activity.
2. Teaches the procedures for each activity early in the year.
3. Rehearses the class so procedures become class routines.

4. Reinforces a procedure when appropriate and reteaches a procedure when necessary.